dinner bet with me that our opinion poll predicting an SP victory would be proven horribly wrong. ‘We will win a minimum of 100 seats, if not 150,’ was his brave prediction. When the Congress barely squeaked past the twenty-five-seat mark, he was honest enough to admit his failure. And he kept his promise and bought me dinner!

For Rahul, though, there was no such consolation. The dependence on the Digvijaya Singh brand of politics had brought him no political return. Instead, he had been exposed as amateurish in his attempt to revive the Congress in the Hindi heartland. Take, for example, a speech he made in Phulpur during the UP election campaign in 2012 while claiming that UP-ites had been forced by failed governments to go and beg in Mumbai. *‘Aapko Mumbai jaakar bheek mangna padta hai. Kab tak bheek mangte rahoge?’* (You have to go and beg in Mumbai. How long will you do so?), he asked the audience. No one likes to be called a beggar. Least of all an economic migrant looking for a better future in the big city. The defeat in UP in 2012 was a hammer blow.

In 2010, Rahul had suffered a similar debacle in neighbouring Bihar. He had made Bihar the test case for his ‘*ekla chalo re*’ (go it alone) political belief—no alliances, the Congress would fight the elections on its own. Lalu Prasad had wanted to revive his Rashtriya Janata Dal’s (RJD) alliance with the Congress. Rahul did not want one. He had spurned Lalu before the 2009 elections as well. *‘Lagta hai ladke ko mera chehra achha nahi lagta!’* (Looks like the boy doesn’t like my face), Lalu told me at the time.

The former Bihar chief minister had enjoyed an excellent equation with Sonia Gandhi. He was the one politician who had stood by Mrs Gandhi when she had been targeted for her foreign origins. In 2004, the Congress–RJD alliance had won twenty-nine of the forty seats in Bihar, and Lalu Prasad was made railway minister. By 2009, the alliance was finished. Lalu was kept waiting for weeks, but the Congress leadership did not oblige—Rahul wanted to strike out on his own.

The experiment of going alone would prove disastrous. In the 2009 general elections, the Congress won just two seats in Bihar. In the 2010 assembly elections, the Congress won just four seats, the RJD (allied with